

Global Spelling Style Guide

Baseline Dictionaries: (for uncovered entries)

British English: Oxford English Dictionary (using -ise endings, outside the exceptions where -ize is unacceptable) or Collins (using -ise endings)

American English: Merriam-Webster (MW) or Oxford American

Canadian English: Oxford Canadian Dictionary

Australian English: Macquarie Dictionary or Australian Oxford Dictionary

Hierarchy of the spelling choice

1. If the word is included in this style guide, you should follow it, like “adviser” instead of “advisor”.
2. For uncovered entries or minor regional differences like “colour” vs “color”, check the dictionary you’re using, shown above, and choose the one for the head entry.
3. If the word is not included even in the dictionary, go to the [UN Editorial Manual - Spelling](#).
4. For the final case, where the word is not included in these three sources, use Wiktionary to check the spelling, but this scenario is highly unusual.

Our Approach to Global English

Languages are never neutral, they are evolving. Forcing either form, like saying “always use US English” as the default standard can be seen as linguistic flattening which alienates global audiences. This guide actively rejects that hierarchy.

For most words, we choose the spellings which can be more accessible for ESL learners and readers with dyslexia to decode better, like **likeable**, keeping the “e” can prevent

mispronouncing as a short “i” sound, **pre-eminent**, using a hyphen to prevent mispronunciation as an inseparable “ee”, **co-authored** with a hyphen to avoid mispronouncing as an “ou” sound or **encyclopedia** using the simplified spelling to enhance readability.

SPELLING EXCEPTIONS AND TRICKY SPELLINGS IN ALL ENGLISH DIALECTS

Hyphens: Hyphenate before the noun, not after the noun: the actor is well known, a well-known actor.

Numbers: Spell out 1-10. Never start a sentence with a number. Advisable to use phrases like “a total number of...” to avoid violating this rule.

For unlisted words, follow the spelling of the HEAD entry.

For words allowing both forms (like enquire and inquire), choose EITHER form to be consistent.

NEVER combine different regional variants (like mixing US color along with UK programme) in the same text.

Adjectives in which the first word ends in -ly are never hyphenated, like “a highly amusing film”.

(Miscellaneous)

1960s (and other similar terms like 2020s, 1400s or 1930s)

3D

4chan

8chan

A, a

A*

abettor

accommodation

acknowledgement is the preferred spelling in BrE and Australian English, acknowledgment in Canadian and American English.

adapter, adaptor: both are acceptable, but adapter is always preferred for tech

advertise

advice (noun), advise (verb)

adviser (not advisor), but advisory

adze

aegis

aeon (philosophy / sci-fi)

aerie

aesthetic (note: use ae)

affect (v), effect (n) generally

African American (not African-American)

Afrobeats

Afrodescendant (noun), Afrodescendent (adj)

AI, AIs

aide-de-camp

aide-mémoire

aircraft or plane (not airplane)

à la mode

Åland Islands

Album, albums

A-level

all right

a lot

aluminium (preferred, recommended spellings) for scientific contexts

alumni (plural), alumna (female singular), alumnus (male singular), alumnae (group of female graduates), also for gender-neutral emerging terms include alumnx and alum (US slang).

amid (not amidst)

amok

among (not amongst)

analogue (noun) (preferred spelling globally as a noun), analog watch

ancien régime, but regime

and (not &, unless it is a part of a proper noun or in titles)

annex (verb), annexe (noun BrE, Australian, Canadian), annex (US)

anti-American

antibiotic

anti-bumping granules

anticlockwise (US: counterclockwise)

antidote

anti-free market (en dash)

antifreeze

anti-hate speech (en dash)

anti-intellectual

antiperspirant

antisemitism

antiseptic

antisocial

anti-terrorism

antithesis (plural antitheses)

anti-war

apartheid

appendices

apprise

apropos

archaeology (note: use ae)

argument

artifact

A's (recommended plural spelling), not as or As (also B's, C's...X's, Y's, Z's)

Asian American

audiobook

Australian Labor Party

avocados

axe

axis, axes

B, b

backlash

Baghdad

balk

bandana

banister

banyan (not banian)

barbecue

barcode

baseline

battalion

bauble

bazaar

Bedouin

bee-eater

belle époque

benefited, benefiting

bestseller

bête noire

biannual, biennial, bimonthly, biweekly

biased

bivouac, bivouacking

BlackBerries

blasé

blond (used for all genders, not blonde)

bogey

bogeyman

bourgeois

braille

bravado

breathe (verb), breath (noun)

briquette

bumblebee

bumf (not bump)

buncombe

Bunsen burner

burqa

businessperson (one word)

buses (not busses)

C, c

cacti

caddy (preferred for containers / devices) / caddie (golf assistant)

caesar salad

caesium (preferred scientifically), cesium is a US variant

café (also cafe), but never cafétéria or cafféine

caffeine, cafeteria (never put an accent even if café takes one)

caliph

calligraphy

callus (noun for hard skin), callous (adj for heartless)

campus, campuses

cancellation (note: cancelled/cancelling remains a regional split)

canister

cannot

canto, cantos

carat

carburettor (British / Australian), carburetor (US)

carousel

casket

cater-corner

cause célèbre

caviar

cellphone (one word)

census, censuses

chameleon

changelog

chastise

chastity

chateau (general spelling) château (accepted Canadian spelling)

cheque (refers to the bank sense), check (US spelling only of the bank sense)

cipher

cliché, clichéd

chilli (British, Australian preferred), chili (American), “Chile” reserves for the Southwestern US for the pepper itself,

clue

co-author

Coca-Cola

cocoa

coconut

codex, codices

co-ed (co-educational)

coequal

coexist

co-founder

collectable

combated

committee

communiqué

complement (add to enhance sth), compliment (praise)

compromise

connection

convener

coolly (never use coolly because it can be a racial slur)

co-op, multiplayer

cooperate

cooperation

cooperative

co-opt

coordinate

coordination

cornerstone

corpora (plural of corpuses)

cosy (preferred in British, Australian, Oxford), cozy is a US variant

counterargument

counter-attack

counterbalance

counter-example

counterproductive

counter-revolutionary

co-worker, co-working

criterion, criteria

czar

D, d

datum (etymologically the singular of data), data, but “data” is acceptable to be used as a singular form in general usage.

daycare

daytime

debacle

debatable

debris

decor (no accent, based on the analogy of decoration)

de-emphasise (British, Australian), de-emphasize (not deemphasize) (American, Canadian)

de-escalate

definitely

déjà vu

demise

denouement

dependable

desiccate

despise

détente, detente (both are acceptable)

devise (verb / plan), device (noun / tool)

dexterous

diagrammed

diarrhoea (British and Australian), diarrhea (American and Canadian)

diaspora

diesel (lowercase)

dietitian

dike

disk (computing), disc (circular objects)

diskette

dispatch

dived (not dove)

doppelgänger

doughnut

dreamed (not dreamt)

drier (adj), dryer (noun)

drought

dryly

duffel

E, e

early 1990s (not hyphenated, also in its similar forms like late 1980s)

earned

Earth, the (capitalised for planet), otherwise if meaning "ground", use earth (lowercase)

ebook

echelon

ecology

eczema

e-commerce

eerie

eg (recommended: for example)

e-learning

elite

email

embarrass

embed

em dash

émigré

éminence grise (but eminence, pre-eminence)

emoji (plural emojis)

enclose

encumbrance

encyclopedia

en dash

endorse

engraft

enquire, inquire: acceptable and interchangeable, though sometimes using enquire for general asking while inquire for official investigations

ensure (make certain that will occur), insure (arrange for compensation)

enterprise

entrust

eon (used in geology) see aeon

e-sports

euro

Eurocentric

everyday (adj), every day (adv. phrase)

excise

exercise

exposé

extracurricular

extraordinary

F, f

façade (also facade)

faeces (British, Australian preferred), feces is the American spelling.

faggot (not fagot) for the British meatball form, but try to avoid this word

fantasy

far-left, far-right

fascia

feldspar

ferrule

fetal

fete

fetid

fetus

fiancé (male), fiancée (female) (note accents)

fiberglass

fiery

filigree

fin de siècle

first-year-old (noun and adj)

flaky

flamboyant

fledgling

flutist

flyer (paper pamphlet), flier (a person who travels on a plane)

focused

foray

forbade

Forebear (an ancestor), forbear (to abstain from sth)

forever

foreword (introductory section), forward (direction of movement or progress), use forwards in BrE, Australian or Canadian English, forward in AmE.

forgo (abstain from), forego (to go before)

formulas (used for tech / general contexts)

formulae (used for maths / chemistry contexts)

franchise

Frédéric Chopin

french fries

fundraising

G, g

gaily (not gayly)

gases

gauge

gauze, as in wire gauze

gelatin

ghetto, ghettos

gibe - means "for a mocking taunt", jibe means "in agreement with" and gybe for "sailing a boat"

gigabyte

glamour, but glamorous

glazier

gluing

goodbye

gourmand

gram (never gramme)

grey

greyhound

grizzly (bear or grey hair), grisly (for something gruesome)

groundbreaking

grovel

guerrilla

guillemot

guttural

gymnasia (singular is gymnasium)

Gypsy (not Gipsy, and recommended to use Romani instead)

gyre

gyro

H, h

haemorrhage (British and Australian), hemorrhage (American and Canadian)

halfway

Hallelujah

Halloween

Hanafi

Hanukkah

harakiri

harelip (avoid; use cleft lip instead)

has (verb he/she/it), haves and have nots (noun)

hauler

Hawai'i, but Hawaiian

healthcare

Heaven-sent

hectogram

hello (not hallo, hullo)

heresy

heroin (drug) heroine (female of hero)

hertz

heterogeneous (with an "e") (diverse in character or content), heterogenous (ends with "-nous") (originating outside the organism)

hiccup

hindrance

hippy

historical novel, historic, a (not "an" historical novel / "an" historic)

homemade

homeopathy

homepage

homework

honorific

hotel

housework

l, i

idyll

ie (recommended to use: that is)

iMac

impostor

improvise

indexes (back of books or general metrics), indices (mathematical, statistical)

Indigenous Peoples

inextricable

inoculate

install

internet, the

incise

inter-office

interracial

interregional

Interrelate

inter-religious

into

intranet

Inuk (singular of Inuit)

iodine

iPad

iPhone

Irish Traveller

iTunes

J, j

jail

jacquard

janissary

jasmine

jelly (not jello)

jerky

jiffy

jihad

jingoism

jockeyed, jockeying

jodhpurs

jonquil

joust

judgment, legal (universal), judgement is accepted in BrE and AusE for the moral or general sense

jujitsu

Junker

junk food

K, k

Kaddish

kaffir lime (avoid, use makrut lime)

kaiser

kaleidoscope

kangaroo

kaolin

karma

kayak

kebab

kedge

keffiyeh

keratin

ketchup

khaki

Khedive

kidnapped

kilogram

kindergarten

Ku Klux Klan

Kyiv

L, I

Labour Day (Hong Kong), Labour Party (UK)

laggard

lambaste

lanolin

lapel

lassos

Latino (Male), Latina (Female), Latiné (Gender-neutral emerging), never Latinx

lavender

layout

leaned (not leant)

leaped (not leapt)

learned (not “learnt”)

leister

LGBT+, LGBTQ+, LGBTQIA+, 2SLGBTQIA+ (Indigenous Two-Spirit)

licence (preferred noun in Commonwealth), license (preferred verb in Commonwealth), in US English use license for everything.

lied, lieder (German loanword)

lifestyle

linchpin

liquefy

liveability (British, Australian), livability (US)

livestream(ing)

llama is the animal, lama means a Tibetan monk

longstanding

long-term (hyphenated before a noun, long term after a noun)

lovable

lowercase

lowlife

low-veld

lycée

M, m

MA

maître d'hôtel (but hotel)

malign

manageable

man-made (avoid; preferred alternatives: artificial or synthetic)

manoeuvre (British, Canadian, Australian), maneuver (US)

Māori (plural remains: the Māori)

marijuana

matinee

matrices

medieval (not mediaeval)

medium (mediums for spiritualism, media for means of communication as the plural)

memento

Métis peoples

metropolis (plural metropolises)

microaggression

microorganism

mid-'90s

midday

midseason

midsummer

Milestone

millennium

minikin

minuscule (never “miniscule”)

Mohawk

mollusc

monarchies

money (plural moneys)

moneyed

monkeyed

Moorish

Morocco

mottoes

movable

MPhil

MPs

Mum (not mom)

multicultural

multi-ethnic

multimedia

museum, museums

Muslim (not Moslem)

must-have

N, n

naïveté / naivety (must be consistent, both are accepted) but never “naiveté”, also both forms are accepted for its derivative, naïve, naive.

nationwide

naught (US), nought (British and Commonwealth)

naughty

necessary

net (not nett)

network

nevertheless

newsfeed

nexus (is the plural already)

night-time

nineteen

ninja

nomad

nonetheless

non-binary

nonconforming

non-cooperation

nondescript

non-existent

non-fat

nonfeasance

non-fiction

non-profit

non-toxic

no one

nuclei (not nucleuses)

O, o

occurrence

offline

ogre

okay (OK is a shorthand which should be avoided in semi-formal and formal writing)

omelette – is the preferred spelling in the UK, Canada and Australia. Omelet is used in AmE.

omitting

one third, three quarters etc (no hyphen for noun, hyphen for adjectives)

online

onomatopoeia (note: use oe)

opportune

orangutan

oriented

outnumber

outperform

out-thinking

overcrowded

overexploitation

overfishing

overleaf

override

overrun

oyes

P, p

pancake

pandemonium

panicked

papier mâché

papoose

parakeet

paralleled

parallelism

passer-by (plural passers-by)

passed (action of movement), past (for time or distance beyond a point)

pastime

pâté

peephole

Pegasus

peony

per annum

per capita

percent, percentage

per diam

pharaoh

PhDs

phial

phoenix

phony

piano, pianos

pièce de résistance

pigeon

pizzazz

polypus (plural polypi)

postcode

post-cold war (en dash)

postcolonial

postgraduate, undergraduate

postmodern

postnatal

post-war

post-WWII

POWs

practice (noun/universal), practise (British/Canadian/Commonwealth verb), practice (used for everything in AmE)

preallocated

précis

precolonial

predate

pre-eclampsia (and all double-e words with pre-)

pre-embryo

pre-eminence

pre-eminent

pre-empt

pre-establish

pre-existing

prejudice

premiere

premium, premiums

pre-recorded

preregister

pre-release

prerequisite

preschool

principle (truth / law), principal (a person of high authority)

Pride (capitalised) but gay pride

profiting

program, computer

prologue

promoter

pro rata

protégé

protester

pseudoscience

psychology

publicly

pygmy

Q, q

quartet

quay

query

queuing (preferred alternative: lining up)

quintuplet

Qur'an

R, r

raccoon

racket

raison d'être

rajah

rarefy

ratafia

reaction

README

reallocate

rearrange

recover (return to a normal state), re-cover (to cover again), hyphenate re- prefixes if it changes semantic meaning)

recreation (amusement), re-creation (the action to create again), also re-create

redo

re-echo (also hyphenate also re- words followed by "e")

re-edit

re-elect

re-emerge

re-employ

re-enact

re-enfranchise

re-engage

re-engineer

re-enrol (British / Australian / Canadian), re-enroll (US) (not reenroll)

re-enter

re-equip

re-establish

re-evaluate

re-examine

re-export

Referable

regime

reinforce (not re-enforce)

reopen

reorganise (BrE, Australian), reorganize (AmE, Canadian) (not re-organise or re-organize)

résumé: preferred spelling in order to avoid confusion with “resume” as a verb

re-upload

re-urge

reuse

revise

rhyme

rhythm

rigmarole

role

routing

run-in

S, s

saccharin

seance

satchel

sautéed (not sautéd)

seething

semi-automatic

semicolon

semicircle

semi-invalid

semi-skilled

Señor

sere (sth withered or dry), sear (to burn sth)

setup (noun), set up (phr verb)

scissors

sheikh

shish kebab

siphon

sizeable (British, Australian), sizable (US)

skeptic

smartphone

snaffle

sneaked (not snuck)

softlock

Sonata, sonatas

soprano, sopranos

soundtrack

southern hemisphere (not capitalised)

spamming

standalone

startup culture

stationary (not moving), stationery (pencils, eraser, ruler etc)

stimulus, stimuli

storey (compare with: story)

straitjacket

subcommittee
subheading
subparagraph
sub-Saharan Africa
subsection
sub-subcommittee
sub-subsection
subtitle
succès de scandale
sulfide
sulfur
supersede
supervise
surmise
surprise
sylvan

T, t

taboo
taffeta
tarmac
tattoo
teamwork

teaspoonfuls

televise

tête-à-tête

textbook

thimblery

tidbit

tikka

TikTok

tithe

thesis (plural theses, also hypothesis, hypotheses)

today

toffee

tomorrow

tollbooth

tourniquet

tranquillity (preferred British, Canadian, Australian), tranquility (US)

trousseau

turnip

tympanum (plural tympana)

U, u

UK, US (full stops redundant)

unbiased

uncommunicative

uncooperative

underlining

under way: avoid, use ongoing instead

UNESCO (not Unesco)

update

Upgrade

uppercase

uproot

up-to-date (pre-noun), up to date (after noun)

urinalysis (plural urinalyses)

usable

username

UTF-8, UTF-16

U-turn

V, v

vapour (British / Commonwealth), vapor (AmE), vaporous (never vapourous, which is a misspelling like humour/humorous pairs in British English), vaporise / vaporize (no u, but ise and ize depend on your dictionary, vaporise British Australian, vaporize Canadian American)

vase

vaudeville

velveteen

ventriloquist

veranda

vice-principal

vice versa

videotape

vigour (British, Australian, Canadian), vigor (US), but vigorous (always no u)

VIP (plural VIPS) (Very important person)

visé (use this spelling for the tool to avoid confusion)

visor

vitamin

voicemail

W, w

watt

warfare

warpath

wash house

weasel

website, webpage

wellbeing

well-known (pre-noun), well known (post-noun)

werewolf

while (not whilst)

whimsy

whippoorwill

whiskey

Wi-Fi

wintry

withhold

wizard

wizened

workforce

workplace, worksite

World Health Organization

worldwide

worthwhile

X, x

xanthophyll

x-coordinate

xenophobia

X-ray

Y, y

yachting

yawl

yeast

y-coordinate

yellowwood

yodel

yogurt

Z, z

zeros

zero-tolerance (hyphenated)

zigzag